

result of this supposed “flaw.” The idea is to imagine what kind of trouble the character usually makes for himself, even without much outside intervention, and let the Storyteller know so that it can be a factor during play.

Some players may find the idea of building flaws into a character to be counterintuitive; after all, if they want to do well at the game, it may seem strange to highlight weak points for the Storyteller to exploit. It’s worth reminding such players that the goal isn’t to avoid the “traps” the Storyteller sets for a character’s weaknesses — playing into a character’s flaws is experiencing the character as conceived. Not only that, but asking them to name some of their favorite characters from fiction or television will provide a host of character flaws, bad behaviors, and other examples of how imperfect characters make for compelling personalities to enjoy.

In the end, building a character with weaknesses as well as strengths makes for a more rounded, believable character than some flawless ideal of heroism. It also makes for a more relatable character, which in turn makes it easier for a player to empathize and engage with his character, leading to greater immersion and deeper roleplaying down the line.

Making Connections

Another good idea during character creation is making sure that every character has some connection to at least one other character in the group. Sometimes this happens naturally, such as the players deciding to be part of a group already — a motley, a rock band, you name it — but sometimes it’s harder to figure out what a group of characters would have in common. That’s where certain connection techniques work well to help players figure out how their characters might come to be a regular group. What follows are but a few possible ways to build ties between characters; groups should feel free to alter or add to these techniques as they see fit.

Sinister Bonds

This technique is simple but effective. The players sit around a table, and go around in a circle where each player makes a connection with the character of the player to their left. It can be anything from oathsworn blood brothers to casual neighbors in the same apartment building, but it has to be something both players agree upon. When a bond is formed, the exercise passes to the next player until the circle is complete. For more thorough connections simply repeat the process, but choosing the player to the right instead.

Hot Seat

In this model, each player takes a turn in the proverbial hot seat and gets the attention of the entire group. This means she introduces her character to the other players, sharing as much as she likes, and then opens the floor to discussion with the other players about how their characters might have run across hers in the past, what they think of her, why they might get together in a group, and so on. When her turn is finished, the next player gets the hot seat, until everyone has had a turn. Don’t forget to write this material down in all the excitement, either!

Pick a Card

With this method, players pair up and draw Tarot cards, using the associated meaning to define the relationship between their characters. For example, if two players draw the Death card for their characters, it could mean there was a failed relationship between the characters — romantic, business, political, etc. Or it could mean that the same failed relationship connects them, such as changelings who are step-siblings as the result of a previous marriage ending in divorce.

Straight Arrows

For this exercise, each player makes a small chart of the characters in the game, with their character in the middle. Nothing elaborate; a name in a box will serve. Each player introduces her character, saying what others might know about them (even if it’s just her appearance). After the introduction, each player draws an arrow to that character on her chart and writes down how her character feels about that character. If characters know each other, the other player may offer his character’s outward attitude or past behavior toward the character as well.

Roll the Bones

Even the best players can get stuck finding connections, and that’s where a little bit of random chance can sometimes shake some inspiration loose. If two players can’t seem to figure out a way to connect their characters, one of them can pick up a die and roll, then consult the chart below for the connection. Note that the result rolled is still open to interpretation. A result of “family” might mean one character is dating another character’s brother, for example, rather than indicating the two characters are actual blood relatives.

Result	Connection
1	School
2	Work
3	Family
4	Romance
5	Rivalry
6	Chrysalis
7	Politics
8	Hobbies
9	Shared Danger
10	Shared Mystery

Character Clash

Sometimes players will want to create characters that really won’t get along, like a group that contains both a haughty sidhe royalist and an angry common revolutionary. This can seem to present the Storyteller with an insurmountable problem in terms of finding reasons to keep the group together, but it’s not necessarily a major issue provided the players involved are willing to work with each other (even if their characters are at odds).